

Chapter 8 — Teacher Admin and Paperwork

25 prompts

None of this is teaching, and all of it takes teaching time. These prompts clear the paperwork quickly and in a professional register — brief, specific, and asking plainly for what you need.

WHAT'S IN HERE

GROUP	PROMPTS	USE WHEN
Staff emails	5	Short, clear, with the ask up front
Agendas and minutes	4	Meetings that end on time and produce something
Professional goals	4	Measurable, and actually achievable
Observation reflections	3	After a lesson observation
Field trip logistics	3	The list you will forget one item from
Clubs and duty plans	3	Running the thing outside lessons
Grants and proposals	3	Asking for money or resources

WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU START

Put the ask in the first line. Everything after it is context, and half your readers will not reach it.

Do not promise a student outcome in a professional goal. "I will do X and gather evidence Y" is a goal you control; "scores will rise 10%" is not.

Anything with a date, an approval, a cost or a policy reference — check it against the real document. The model will produce a plausible date.

Ask for the one-line hallway version alongside the email. You will use it more.

STAFF EMAILS

AD-003 Write a concise staff email with one clear action

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

An email that gets done rather than filed.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write a staff email.

To: [ROLE OR TEAM]

What I need: [THE ONE ACTION]

By when: [DATE]

Context they need: [ONLY WHAT IS NECESSARY]

Rules:

- The ask is in the first line. Context comes after
- One action only. If I have given you two, tell me to send two emails
- Under 120 words
- Subject line under 8 words, naming the action and the deadline
- No apology for emailing, no "just", no "sorry to bother"
- Say what happens if they do nothing, if that matters

Give me the email, the subject line, and a one-line version for a corridor conversation.

Use only the facts I supplied. Do not invent a date, a policy or a reason.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is the ask genuinely in the first line?
- Is it one action?

AD-004 Turn rough notes into a professional colleague update

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Bullet points in your head, something readable out.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Turn these notes into an update for [WHO]:

[PASTE YOUR ROUGH NOTES]

Give me:

- The update, organised so the most important thing is first
- What is a decision, what is progress, and what is a problem – kept separate
- Anything in my notes that is my opinion rather than fact, marked as such
- Anything I have implied but not stated, so I can decide whether to state it
- Under 200 words

Do not add anything I did not write. If a note is too cryptic to expand, quote it back and ask.

Then tell me what a reader would still not know after reading this.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Has anything been added that you did not write?
- Is opinion clearly separated from fact?

AD-005 Draft a meeting request with purpose, preparation and time limit

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

So the meeting is short and the right people come prepared.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write a meeting request.

Purpose: [WHAT MUST BE DECIDED OR RESOLVED]

Who: [ROLES]

Length: [MINUTES]

Options: [TWO SPECIFIC DATES AND TIMES]

Give me:

- The request, with the purpose in one sentence
- What each person should bring or think about beforehand
- The decision the meeting exists to reach
- What happens if we cannot meet – the asynchronous alternative
- Under 120 words

Rules:

- Say plainly whether attendance is required or optional
- Do not schedule a meeting for something that could be an email – if that is what I have described, say so
- No agenda longer than the meeting can hold

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- If it said this could be an email, it probably could.
- Is the preparation realistic for people's actual week?

AD-006 Write a follow-up email that separates decisions from open questions

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

So nobody leaves the meeting with a different version of what happened.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write a follow-up after a meeting.

What was discussed: [YOUR NOTES]

What was decided: [LIST IT]

What was not resolved: [LIST IT]

Structure it in three clearly separated parts:

- Decisions, each with who and by when
- Open questions, each with who will resolve it and by when
- Everything else, briefly

Rules:

- Record only decisions actually made. If something was discussed but not decided, it goes in open questions, not decisions
- Every item has a named owner. No unowned items
- No decision attributed to a person who did not make it
- Invite correction

Flag anything in my notes that I have recorded as agreed but reads as unresolved.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Has anything moved from "discussed" to "decided"?
- Does every item have an owner?

AD-007 Audit a staff email for tone, recipients, dates and unnecessary detail

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Before you send it to twelve people, one of whom will forward it.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this staff email: [PASTE IT]

Tell me:

- Whether the ask is clear, single, and in the first two lines
- Every date, name and figure I should verify before sending
- Anything that reads as blame, frustration or passive aggression, quoted
- Anyone on the recipient list who does not need this, and anyone missing
- What could be cut with no loss
- Anything that would read badly if forwarded to someone I did not intend

Then tell me the one sentence I should delete, and whether this needs to be an email at all.

Be direct about tone. I wrote it and cannot hear it any more.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- The tone flags: trust them over your own ear.
- Verify every date and figure.

AGENDAS AND MINUTES

AD-008 Build a timed agenda around decisions that must be made

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A meeting that ends on time because it was built to.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build an agenda for a [MINUTES]-minute meeting.

Purpose: [WHAT MUST BE DECIDED]

Attendees: [ROLES]

Items I have been given: [LIST THEM]

Give me:

- The agenda with minutes per item, adding up to less than the meeting length
- Each item labelled: decision, discussion, or information
- Information items grouped at the end or moved to writing entirely
- The decision that matters most, placed first
- What we do if we run out of time on item one
- What each attendee needs before the meeting

Rules:

- No item without a stated outcome
- If the items cannot fit honestly, say which to drop rather than compressing everything
- Anything purely informational should not be in a meeting; say so

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Do the minutes add up with slack, or exactly?
- Are the information items really necessary in the room?

AD-001 Turn notes into accountable meeting minutes

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Minutes people can act on rather than skim.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Turn these meeting notes into minutes:

[PASTE YOUR NOTES]

Structure:

- Decisions: what was decided, who decided, effective when
- Actions: what, who, by when
- Open: what was raised and not resolved, and who is picking it up
- Noted: information shared, briefly

Rules:

- Record only what my notes contain. Do not smooth a disagreement into consensus, and do not record agreement that was not stated
- Every action has a named owner and a date. If my notes lack one, write [OWNER?] or [DATE?] rather than assigning it yourself
- Where people disagreed, record that they disagreed
- No interpretation of anyone's tone or intent

Then list every point where my notes were ambiguous about who agreed to what.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Fill in every [OWNER?] and [DATE?] before circulating.
- Has any disagreement been smoothed over?

AD-009 Convert discussion notes into decisions, actions and a parking lot

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

An hour of discussion, and you need to know what actually came of it.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Sort these discussion notes into three piles:

[PASTE THE NOTES]

- DECIDED: settled, with who and when
- ACTION: someone will do something, with who and by when
- PARKING LOT: raised, not resolved, and not being carried forward now

Rules:

- A thing is only DECIDED if my notes show it was decided. Being discussed at length is not deciding
- Nothing in ACTION without an owner. Mark [OWNER?] where my notes do not say
- The parking lot needs a date to revisit, or it needs deleting – say which

Then tell me:

- What we spent the most time on, and which pile it ended in
- Anything that will come back at the next meeting because it was not settled

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is anything in DECIDED that was only discussed?
- Does the parking lot have a revisit date, or should it be dropped?

AD-010 Audit meeting minutes for invented consensus, owners or deadlines

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Minutes become the record. Getting them wrong is expensive later.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit these minutes against my notes.

MINUTES: [PASTE THEM]

MY NOTES: [PASTE THEM]

Tell me:

- Anything recorded as agreed that my notes do not support
- Any owner assigned who did not accept the action
- Any deadline that appears in the minutes but not in my notes
- Anywhere disagreement has been smoothed into consensus
- Anything attributed to a person who did not say it
- Anything in my notes that is missing from the minutes

Quote each one.

Then tell me which entry would cause the most trouble in three months if it is wrong.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Anything it flagged as invented: remove it, do not soften it.
- Circulate for correction before treating these as final.

PROFESSIONAL GOALS

AD-002 Draft a measurable professional growth goal

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A goal you control, not a wish about your students.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Draft a professional growth goal for this year.

What I want to get better at: [DESCRIBE IT]

Why: [WHAT PROMPTED THIS]

Time available: [BE HONEST]

Rules – the first one matters most:

- The goal must be about what I will do, not what students will achieve. I do not control their outcomes and should not be held to them
- No percentage improvements in student scores
- The action must fit the time I stated. If it does not, say so
- The evidence must be something I can actually gather while teaching full time

Give me:

- The goal in one sentence
- The specific actions, with when
- The evidence I collect, and how long collecting it takes each week
- What would make me revise this goal mid-year

Then tell me what this goal will cost me, honestly.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is it about your practice or students' scores?
- Could you actually gather that evidence in a normal week?

AD-011 Turn baseline evidence into a realistic semester action plan

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Starting from where you actually are.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a semester action plan from this baseline:

Where I am now: [DESCRIBE, WITH EVIDENCE]

Where I want to be: [DESCRIBE]

Constraints: [TIME, TEACHING LOAD, ANYTHING ELSE]

Give me:

- A plan across [NUMBER] weeks, with what happens in which week
- The two weeks in the term where this will not happen – reports, exams, whatever I told you – and how the plan survives them
- What I stop doing to make room. A plan that adds without removing will fail
- The smallest version of this plan, for a bad term

Do not plan for an ideal term. Plan for a normal one.

Then tell me the week this plan is most likely to be abandoned, and what would keep it alive.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does it say what you stop doing? If not, it will not survive.
- Is the smallest version still worth doing?

AD-012 Create leading and outcome indicators for a teaching goal

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Knowing in week four whether this is working.

COPY THIS PROMPT

For this professional goal – [PASTE IT] – give me indicators.

Two kinds, kept separate:

- Leading indicators: things I can see within weeks, about what I am doing
- Outcome indicators: things that would show it made a difference, later

For each:

- What it is, specifically
- How I measure it, in under five minutes a week
- What a good early sign looks like, and what a bad one looks like

Rules:

- Leading indicators must be about my practice, not student results
- Outcome indicators may involve students, but state honestly how much I can attribute to this goal – probably less than I would like
- No indicator requiring extra data collection I will not sustain

Then tell me which indicator I will stop tracking first, and whether that matters.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Which will you stop tracking? Be honest, then drop it now.
- Is the attribution claim honest?

AD-013 Build midpoint decision rules for revising a professional goal

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Deciding in advance what would make you change course.

COPY THIS PROMPT

For this goal – [PASTE IT] – write midpoint decision rules.

Give me:

- What I check at the midpoint, and how long that check takes
- Three outcomes: on track, partly working, not working
- For each, the specific decision – continue, adjust how, or stop
- What "not working" actually looks like, described concretely enough that I cannot talk myself out of it
- What I would need to see to justify abandoning this goal entirely

Rules:

- Write the rules now, so the midpoint me cannot rationalise
- Abandoning a goal that is not working is a legitimate outcome. Say so
- Do not build in a rule that always produces "keep going"

Then tell me which outcome I am most likely to misread as success.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is "not working" described concretely enough to be undeniable?
- Would you accept stopping as an outcome?

OBSERVATION REFLECTIONS

AD-014 Write an evidence-based reflection after a classroom observation

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

After the observation, before the meeting.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Help me write a reflection after a classroom observation.

What happened in the lesson: [DESCRIBE – no student names]

Feedback I received: [PASTE OR SUMMARISE]

How I feel about it: [BE HONEST – this is for my thinking, not the document]

Give me:

- The reflection, based on observable events rather than on how it felt
- Where I agree with the feedback, and why
- Where I do not, stated professionally with the evidence for my view
- What I genuinely do not know yet
- One thing I will do differently, and how I will know whether it helped

Rules:

- Do not simply agree with everything to be safe
- Do not be defensive either
- Keep my feelings out of the written version, but tell me if they are pointing at something worth examining

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does the disagreement read as professional or defensive?
- Is the "one thing" small enough to actually do?

AD-015 Separate observed events, interpretation and next action

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Feedback that mixes what happened with what it meant.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Sort this observation feedback into three columns:

[PASTE THE FEEDBACK]

- OBSERVED: what actually happened in the room
- INTERPRETED: what the observer concluded from it
- RECOMMENDED: what they suggest

For each interpretation, tell me:

- Which observation supports it
- Whether another interpretation would fit the same observation
- Whether the observer had context they may not have had – a prior lesson, a student's circumstances, what I was deliberately doing

Then tell me:

- Which recommendation follows clearly from the evidence
- Which rests on an interpretation I could reasonably question
- The one recommendation to act on first

Do not dismiss feedback because an alternative interpretation exists.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Are you questioning an interpretation, or avoiding the feedback?
- Does the observer's missing context actually change it?

AD-016 Turn observer feedback into one measurable instructional experiment

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Six suggestions, and you have room for one.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Turn this feedback into one small experiment I can run:

[PASTE THE FEEDBACK]

Constraints: [TIME, CLASSES, WHAT IS ALREADY ON]

Give me:

- The single change, small enough to try in a fortnight
- Exactly what I do differently, described so I could do it tomorrow
- What I look for to know whether it worked
- How long before I judge it – long enough to be fair, short enough to matter
- What I do if it makes things worse

Rules:

- One change. If I try three I will not know which did anything
- It must be something I can sustain, not something that works because I am paying it unusual attention
- Say which of the suggestions I am setting aside, so I know what I am not doing

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is it genuinely one change?
- Could you sustain it after the novelty wears off?

FIELD TRIP LOGISTICS

AD-017 Build a field-trip planning checklist from official requirements

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The list you will otherwise forget one item from.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a planning checklist for a trip.

Destination and activity: [DESCRIBE]

Date, group size, year group: [STATE THEM]

My school's stated requirements: [PASTE OR SUMMARISE WHAT YOU HAVE]

Give me a checklist ordered by deadline, working backwards from the trip date, covering: approvals, consent, transport, staffing, medical and dietary information, money, communication, and what happens on the day.

Rules:

- Use only the requirements I supplied. Do not state a ratio, a form, a timescale or a policy I did not give you
- Where a standard requirement is missing from what I supplied, list it as [CHECK WITH SCHOOL] rather than filling it in
- Mark which items are legal or policy requirements versus good practice, only where I told you which is which

I will verify every item against my school's own procedures before relying on this.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Take every [CHECK WITH SCHOOL] to the person who actually knows.
- Do not treat any stated ratio or timescale as authoritative.

AD-018 Create a trip-day schedule with owners, counts and contingency fields

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The single sheet every adult carries on the day.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a trip-day schedule.

Timings: [WHAT YOU KNOW – departure, arrival, activities, return]

Adults: [HOW MANY, AND THEIR ROLES]

Students: [NUMBER, GROUPS]

Give me a one-page schedule with:

- Each time slot, what happens, and which adult is responsible
- Head-count points, with a box to write the number and the time
- Where each group is at any given moment
- Blank fields for contact numbers and the meeting point
- What to do if the group is running late – who is told, in what order
- What to do if a student is separated from the group

Rules:

- Every slot has a named responsible adult. No unowned time
- Leave [BLANK] for anything I did not give you, including emergency contacts
- It must be readable on paper, on a windy pavement, folded in a pocket

I will check the emergency and safeguarding elements against my school's procedures.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Fill every [BLANK], especially contacts.
- Print it. It has to work without a phone.

AD-019 Audit a field-trip draft for permissions, access, safety and unknowns

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Before it goes to whoever approves trips.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this trip plan: [PASTE IT]

Tell me:

- What is missing that a trip plan normally contains
- Every consent, medical or emergency element that appears incomplete
- Anything assuming a student can walk far, climb stairs, tolerate noise, eat a standard meal, swim, or afford a cost
- What happens to a student whose family cannot pay, and whether that is stated
- Anything stated as a school or venue policy that I should verify
- What is not planned for: bad weather, a late coach, a student who is unwell, a group returning after the school day ends
- Every unknown I have written as though it were settled

List the accessibility gaps separately. A trip a student cannot join is a problem to solve before booking, not on the day.

I will verify all safeguarding and consent requirements with my school.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Solve the accessibility gaps before booking, not after.
- Every "verify" flag goes to the person who approves trips.

CLUBS AND DUTY PLANS

AD-020 Create a club launch plan with purpose, routines and supervision fields

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Starting something that will still be running in March.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Plan the launch of a [CLUB OR ACTIVITY] for [GRADE] students.

When and where: [DETAILS]

How many students: [NUMBER OR LIMIT]

What I have: [SPACE, EQUIPMENT, OTHER ADULTS]

Give me:

- The purpose in one sentence, so I can say no to things that are not it
- The first three sessions, in enough detail to run them
- The routines: arriving, starting, packing up, leaving
- How students join, and what happens if more want to come than I can take
- What I need to confirm before the first session – supervision, permission, access – as [CONFIRM] items rather than assumptions
- What makes this sustainable in week ten, when the novelty is gone

Do not state a supervision requirement or ratio. Mark it [CONFIRM WITH SCHOOL].

Then tell me the most likely reason this club stops running.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Every [CONFIRM] before session one, not after.
- Is the week-ten answer honest?

AD-021 Build a fair duty rota from supplied availability and policy

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A rota nobody can reasonably call unfair.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a duty rota.

Duties to cover: [LIST THEM, WITH TIMES]

People available: [LIST, WITH THEIR CONSTRAINTS AND ANY EXEMPTIONS]

Period: [HOW MANY WEEKS]

Rules I have been given: [PASTE THEM]

Give me:

- The rota, week by week
- A count of duties per person, so the distribution is visible
- Who has the least desirable slots, and how those rotate
- What happens when someone is absent
- Anything I asked for that cannot be covered with the people available

Rules:

- Use only the availability and constraints I gave you
- Do not assume anyone can cover outside their stated availability
- If the rota cannot be filled fairly, say so plainly rather than producing an uneven one that looks complete

Then tell me who will feel hardest done by, and whether they would be right.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Check the duty counts yourself.
- If it says it cannot be filled fairly, take that upward.

AD-022 Audit a club or duty plan for gaps, overload and unclear responsibility

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Before it runs and the gap becomes obvious.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this club or duty plan: [PASTE IT]

Tell me:

- Any time period with no named adult responsible
- Any handover point where responsibility is ambiguous – arriving, leaving, between activities
- Anyone carrying noticeably more than others
- What happens when a person is absent, and whether that is planned or assumed
- Anything requiring an adult to be in two places
- Anything assuming a student can stay late, get home afterwards, or afford to take part

Then tell me:

- The single riskiest gap
- Whether this plan works on a week when two people are ill

I will confirm all supervision requirements with my school.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Close the riskiest gap before it runs.
- Does it survive two absences?

GRANTS AND PROPOSALS

AD-023 Turn a verified classroom need into a concise proposal outline

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Asking for something, briefly and credibly.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Outline a proposal for [WHAT YOU WANT].

The need, with evidence: [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU HAVE OBSERVED OR RECORDED]

Who I am asking: [ROLE OR BODY]

Rough cost: [IF KNOWN]

Give me an outline covering:

- The need, in two sentences, evidenced
- What I am asking for, specifically
- What changes if it is funded, stated as what becomes possible rather than what will be achieved
- What happens if it is not
- How I would know afterwards whether it was worth it

Rules:

- Use only the evidence I gave you. Do not invent a statistic, a comparison school, or a research finding
- No claim about improved outcomes that I cannot support
- If my evidence is too thin to justify the ask, say so and tell me what to gather first

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- If it said the evidence is thin, gather more before asking.
- Any statistic in there that you did not supply? Remove it.

AD-024 Build a grant budget narrative from supplied costs and restrictions

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Explaining the numbers so they are believed.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write the budget narrative for a proposal.

Costs: [ITEMISE WHAT YOU HAVE, WITH SOURCES]

Restrictions: [WHAT THE FUNDER WILL AND WILL NOT COVER]

Total requested: [AMOUNT]

Give me:

- A narrative explaining each cost and why it is necessary
- The arithmetic, shown, so a reader can check it
- Anything that falls outside the stated restrictions, flagged
- What is ongoing versus one-off, and who covers the ongoing part
- What I would cut first if only part is funded

Rules:

- Use only the figures I supplied. Do not estimate, round, or add a contingency
 - I did not state
- Check every total and state that you have
- Where a cost is missing that a funder would expect, list it as missing

I will verify all figures and the funder's terms myself before submitting.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Re-add every column yourself.
- Check the restrictions against the funder's actual terms.

AD-025 Audit a proposal for unsupported claims, missing evidence and compliance

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The last read before it is submitted.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this proposal: [PASTE IT]

Requirements I was given: [PASTE THEM, IF ANY]

Tell me:

- Every claim not supported by evidence in the proposal itself, quoted
- Every statistic, research reference or comparison – and whether I supplied it
or it appeared from nowhere
- Any promise about outcomes I cannot guarantee
- Any requirement from the guidance that the proposal does not address
- Any arithmetic error
- Anything a sceptical reader would ask that this does not answer

Then tell me:

- The weakest claim, which is where it will be challenged
- Whether the ask is proportionate to the evidence

Do not soften this. A proposal declined for overreach is worse than one that asked for less.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Any statistic you did not supply: delete it, do not verify it later.
- Re-check the arithmetic yourself.